



and the islands are home to nine active volcanoes. There are over 100 indigenous languages in Vanuatu, but most people speak or understand a form of pidgin, based on English. Vanuatu is home to

a rich Melanesian culture full of tradition, magic, and ritual, and each tribal group on the islands has its own identity and customs.

The great Pentecost jump

Every April, when the first yam crop is ready for harvest, the inhabitants of Pentecost Island start to build a huge tower, which will end up 100 ft (30 m) high. After five weeks the tower is ready, and over the next few weeks boys and men jump from the top with only lianas vines attached to their feet. They believe that this will make the ground fertile.

LIFE OR DEATH

The men have to choose their own length of vine and, as they must aim for the vine to tighten as near to the ground as possible, the length is of vital importance. A vine just 4 in (10 cm) too long could mean serious injury or death.



1 The first jump
A boy jumps for the first time when he enters manhood, and from then on jumps regularly. His ankles are tied tightly with the vine and attached to the top of the tower.



2 Reach for the sky
The land diver always stretches his arms toward the sky before jumping. The divers believe that the higher the jumpers dive, the higher the crop will grow.



3 The jump
With the whole community watching, the diver then hurls himself off the top of the tower. It is quite common for people to die during the fall.

BUNGEE JUMPING

Modern-day bungee jumping was inspired by the ancient Pentecost jump. The only difference is that the modern jumpers use elastic, which is much safer!

